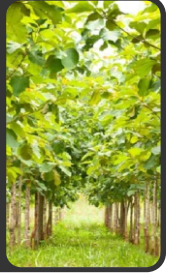


4. GOOD TIMBER

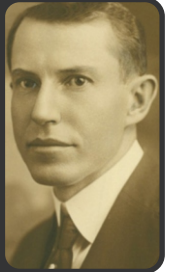
BY DOUGLAS MALLOCH

May 5, 1877 – July 2, 1938

"Good Timber" by Douglas Malloch uses the metaphor of trees to highlight the importance of resilience and personal growth. The poem compares individuals to trees, suggesting that, like trees that grow strong by enduring storms, people develop strength and character by facing challenges. It encourages perseverance and teaches that true strength is built through adversity.

**ABOUT THE POET**

Douglas Malloch (May 5, 1877 – July 2, 1938) was an American poet, short-story writer and Associate Editor of *American Lumberman*, a trade paper in Chicago. He was known as a "Lumberman's poet" both locally and nationally. He is noted for writing *Round River Drive* and "Be the Best of Whatever You Are" in addition to many other creations. He was commissioned to write new lyrics for the Michigan State Song, *Michigan, My Michigan* in 1902.

**SUMMARY**

'Good Timber' is one of Douglas Malloch's most popular poems and a poem which uses extended metaphor. It focuses on subject matter and themes that are frequently a part of his work. He wrote about the woods, lumberjacks, and adventure stories. This imagery is all present in 'Good Timber'. Throughout the poem, Malloch uses simple language, diction, and standard syntax in order to get his main points across. The poem is meant to be accessible to all readers. This makes a great deal of sense as the themes at the heart of the poem apply to all people, no matter who they are or where they're from. The poem begins with the speaker describing how there are two types of trees and men. First, there are those who are readily given everything they need to survive. This type of person or tree never has to worry about where their food and water is going to come from. On the other hand, there are the trees and men who must fight, from birth, to survive. Their broken branches and scars are evidence of their ability to survive on and become "forest king[s]."

The tree that never had to fight
For sun and sky and air and light,
But stood out in the open plain
And always got its share of rain,
Never became a forest king
But lived and died a scrubby thing.

The man who never had to toil
To gain and farm his patch of soil,
Who never had to win his share
Of sun and sky and light and air,
Never became a manly man
But lived and died as he began.

Good timber does not grow with ease,
The stronger wind, the stronger trees,
The further sky, the greater length,
The more the storm, the more the strength.
By sun and cold, by rain and snow,
In trees and men good timbers grow.

Where thickest lies the forest growth
We find the patriarchs of both.
And they hold counsel with the stars
Whose broken branches show the scars
Of many winds and much of strife.
This is the common law of life.

EXERCISE 1- POST READING

1. What is the significance of the title of the poem 'Good Timber'?

Ans. The title of the poem 'Good Timber' holds significance with respect to the message of the poem. The poet has artfully compared good timber with good men. He believes that it is not easy for both timber and men to become good without going through hard times. It is a bare fact that the more they suffer, the more they become worthwhile and beneficial for the society.. According to the poet, good timber fighting through forest growth to reach the sun, that we grow and discover our true potential. Anyone who struggles in the life becomes strong whether it is good timber or a man.

2. What, according to Douglas Malloch, is the fate of those people who do not work hard in life?

Ans. According to Douglas Malloch, those people who do not work hard never excel in any field of life. They can not have a strong personality and can never develop their social, moral, and economic position. Such people live and die without achieving anything significant in their life.

3. How can a person achieve his/her true potential in life? Illustrate it with examples from the poem 'Good Timber'.

Ans. A person can achieve his true potential only when he faces hardships, difficulties and tough times with courage and determination. According to the poet, a man becomes strong when encounters and overcomes adversity in life. Hardships, unfavourable conditions, difficult situations polish our abilities and capabilities thus, help us in becoming good human beings. A person does not become strong if he gets everything easily without putting in hard work. Douglas compares good timber with men as timber has to bear harsh winds, rain, sunshine, and snow to become good and beneficial, same is the case with men.

4. What is the central idea of the poem 'Good Timber'? or What is the rhyme scheme of the poem 'Good Timber'?

Ans. The central idea of the poem 'Good Timber' is that in order to become good and beneficial one has to face hardships and difficulties in life. Both timber and man have to overcome adversity with courage and determination. Struggle is a key to success to live a perfect, valuable life otherwise both of them die without achieving anything worthwhile in their life.

The poet compared good man as a good timber in this metaphorical poem. The message of this poem is that people, like trees, grow and reach to their true potentiality by overcoming all the adversity. According to the poet, good timber keeps fighting through forest growth to reach the sun. So, we grow and discover our true potential when we struggle in the life. Anyone who struggles in life, becomes strong whether it is good timber or a man.

5. What is good timber? How does tree grow into good timber?

Ans. Good timber faces adversity and hard times with bravery. It is the one that encounters the forces of nature such as strong winds and unfavourable conditions throughout life, due to this it becomes vital, good, and beneficial. A tree can only grow into good timber when it passes through the tough test of the scorching sun, cold and hot weather, snow, rain.